



After Action Review Report
The Response to Political Transition in Bangladesh
August 2024-October 2025

July 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Background

Bangladesh experienced a major political transition in 2024 following widespread student-led protests initially triggered by the reinstatement of a controversial public sector job quota system. The demonstrations evolved into a nationwide movement, reflecting a range of public concerns related to governance, economic conditions and civic space. On 5th August 2024, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina fled the country, leading to a period of political uncertainty and subsequent formation of an interim administration headed by Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus. This transition marked a pivotal moment in Bangladesh's political landscape, opening space for reforms while also creating a complex and fluid operating environment.

In response to the evolving situation, UNDP activated its corporate crisis response mechanisms, and the Crisis Board classified the situation as a Level 3 crisis in August 2024. The Corporate response spanned between August 2024 – October 2025 and provided technical support through immediate SURGE deployments and funding support from TRAC3 and Funding Window.

Following the response and as per the Crisis Response and Recovery SOPs, UNDP is undertaking an After Action Review (AAR), which aims to provide a structured reflection on the crisis response to identify strengths and weaknesses; lessons learned and good practices; to sustain and multiply what was done well, and to identify and address areas for improvement. The present AAR, designed as a light exercise, covers the period of activation of the corporate response to the Bangladesh crisis, with a focus on coordination and clarity in decision-making, the effectiveness of programme interventions and corporate support mechanisms, and the performance of operational functions during the crisis.

Analysis of the Response

Overall, the Review finds that UNDP demonstrated strong institutional capacity and adaptability in responding to the political transition. Coordination between Regional Bureau of Asia and the Pacific (RBAP), the Crisis Bureau (CB), and the Bangladesh CO was effective, with the Bangkok Regional Hub (BRH) serving as the main coordination channel and first responder. Early engagement from regional and headquarters teams helped maintain situational awareness and supported the CO during a rapidly evolving and uncertain period.

Strong leadership from the CO, under the direction of the Resident Representative, played a central role in shaping the response. The CO acted decisively to position UNDP in priority reform areas such as governance, elections, justice sector reform, and civic engagement. Rapid deployment of multidisciplinary SURGE advisors provided specialized expertise and enabled UNDP to engage early with the interim government and reform commissions.

Flexible coordination arrangements between the CO and the BRH, supported by frequent communication and streamlined decision-making channels, facilitated timely responses and alignment around emerging priorities. Access to flexible crisis funding also proved catalytic, allowing UNDP to initiate early support for electoral processes and governance reforms. These early investments strengthened credibility with national counterparts and helped mobilize significant donor resources for governance and electoral support.

KEY OBSERVATIONS, LESSONS LEARNED AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The response highlighted several strengths that contributed to UNDP's effectiveness during the political transition. Early strategic positioning, strong CO leadership, the rapid deployment of regionally knowledgeable SURGE advisors, and flexible coordination arrangements enabled timely and meaningful engagement during

a critical moment. The role of the BRH as a first responder was particularly important in providing contextually informed support and sustaining effective coordination between headquarters and the CO.

At the same time, the crisis response revealed areas requiring further strengthening. Preparedness for political crises was limited, particularly with regard to political risk monitoring, scenario planning, and contingency measures for disruptions such as internet shutdowns. Operational challenges emerged in alternative reliable communications, especially during internet blackouts, strengthening Business Continuity Planning, and applying and monitoring of corporate Special Measures. These lessons underscore the need for stronger preparedness frameworks and tools tailored specifically to political transition contexts.

Key Observations and Lessons Learned

1. Coordination and timely support

The Bangladesh response demonstrated UNDP's strong institutional capacity, with effective coordination between RBAP, CB, and the CO. The BRH served as the main coordination channel and first responder. Coordination and support were centralized through a small core group in BRH, reducing duplication and managing information flow, which minimized fragmentation and overlapping support. Overall, the response was timely, pragmatic, and largely aligned with the CO's evolving needs, despite initial uncertainty about nature and scale of support.

2. Strong leadership and early strategic positioning

The UNDP CO senior management, led by the RR, provided strong and decisive leadership, ensuring a clear, organized, and strategic crisis response. With well-defined roles and high trust among teams and SURGE Advisors, the CO Senior Management made timely decisions and took calculated risks, positioning UNDP early in priority areas. Their coherent vision, preparedness, and effective coordination within the UN system enabled swift action, maintained strategic engagement, and balanced neutrality with meaningful involvement. This early leadership established UNDP's credibility and distinct niche compared to other UN agencies which were more cautious in their engagement.

3. Rapid deployment of SURGE Advisors

Rapid SURGE deployments and specialized advisory support, particularly in governance, elections, justice reform, partnerships, and civic engagement, had a significant strategic impact in the early days of the crisis. These advisors helped position UNDP credibly with the interim government and reform commissions. The key elements that enhanced effectiveness were the advisors' grounded knowledge of the context and dynamics, as well as their substantive experience working with national institutions. Six- to twelve-week deployments also helped ensure sustained support.

4. Flexible coordination enabling timely response

Small, focused coordination arrangements between the CO and BRH, supported by frequent weekly—and at times daily—calls between the RR, DRR, and BRH teams, along with flexible communication channels, enabled faster decision-making and effective alignment on priorities and support. In a political transition context with rapidly changing dynamics, flexible and nimble coordination mechanisms at regional level can respond quickly to CO needs and requests, in between the convening of the more formal structures like Crisis Board and the CMST. Lessons from Bangladesh suggest that future responses should prioritize a demand-driven approach tailored to CO priorities, to complement corporate coordination mechanisms.

5. Flexible funding

Access to flexible funding enabled the CO to respond in a timely manner to government requests, enhance credibility, and mobilize larger donor financing. Funding Window contributions were catalytic, enabling UNDP to initiate critical electoral assistance that later attracted over USD 11 million, and triggered bilateral Agreements of more than USD 6 million to support governance work and nationwide Justice Reform consultations.

6. Gaps in crisis preparedness

The crisis highlighted opportunities to strengthen the CO's preparedness for responding to sudden service disruptions. It underscored the need for enhanced risk analysis, more robust Business Continuity Planning, and the development of Standard Operating Procedures for scenarios such as complete internet shutdowns. These experiences provide valuable guidance for improving preparedness frameworks, particularly in the context of Bangladesh's dynamic and sometimes unpredictable security environment following periods of unrest.

Second, the CO acknowledged the need for stronger Early Warning Systems, Scenario-based Planning, Political Economy Analysis, and Risk Analysis as well as Monitoring as essential components for improving preparedness.

Third, available resources and guidance through Early Recovery Hub were insufficient for responding to a political transition context, as most resources were designed primarily for natural disasters.

Recommendations

1. Country Office

- **Strengthen CO crisis preparedness:** COs operating in politically volatile environments should systematically integrate political risk monitoring and scenario-based contingency planning into their regular practices. This includes conducting regular Political Economy Analysis, organizing crisis simulations, and maintaining updated Business Continuity Plans that address potential disruptions such as internet shutdowns, mobility restrictions, or civil unrest.
- **Strengthen HR preparedness:** Consider pre-identifying critical positions and establish rapid recruitment pipelines or maintain pre-cleared candidate rosters (ICs) to enable timely deployment during crisis response. In addition, CO could leverage the Crisis Bureau's pre-classified crisis-related Terms of Reference, which can be activated under special measures to expedite recruitment processes. This would help fulfill the immediate gaps while longer-term recruitment processes are underway, ensuring continuity and responsiveness during crisis.
- **Enhance SURGE deployment effectiveness:** Develop and share CO's Mission Plan within the first 1–2 days of deployment, outlining roles, responsibilities, and expectations. Additionally, the CO should designate a dedicated focal point for programme coordination. This would streamline communication, improve alignment across teams, and clarify responsibilities, allowing SURGE Advisors to focus on delivering vital technical support rather than coordination functions.

2. Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific

- **Maintaining and Strengthening the Regional Hub as a First Responder:** The role of the Regional Hub as a first responder should be sustained and further strengthened, given its critical importance in providing timely and context specific support to COs during crises. This includes enhancing regional SURGE capacity in key areas such as Governance, Elections, Peacebuilding, and Political Economy to enable rapid deployment to countries undergoing political transitions, while ensuring that advisors who are likely to be deployed complete SURGE training in advance, either by participating in scheduled training opportunities or by undertaking the self-paced online course.
- **Enhance Regional knowledge-sharing:** Promote cross-country learning (example- exchange between Nepal and Bangladesh) and help COs anticipate challenges and opportunities during periods of political transition.

3. Crisis Bureau

- **Strengthening CO capacity to effectively respond to conflict and/or political transition crises**

- **In coordination with RBAP,** provide support and guidance to the COs in key areas such as risk monitoring, scenario planning, and political economy analysis to enable more timely and informed responses.
- **Adapt crisis tools for political transition contexts:** Expand crisis response resources and early recovery hub tools to better reflect the needs of political transition and conflict settings, recognizing that the ERH currently focuses primarily on disaster-related crisis response. This includes developing standard Terms of Reference for priority areas such as youth and civic engagement, as well as social cohesion. Consolidating relevant guidance and resources within the GRP Hub would improve accessibility and support more effective CO responses.
- **Continue providing orientation on Special Measures:** Continue organizing dedicated sessions for COs on Special Measures, ensuring they can clearly understand and apply the appropriate measures based on their operating context.
- **Strengthen conflict-sensitive programming skills:** Consider organizing refresher training for SURGE Advisors on conflict-sensitive programming to enhance effectiveness, particularly in political transition environments.
- **Promote and facilitate inter-regional peer learning exchanges** by creating opportunities for teams across regions to share experiences, lessons learned, and good practices. This will strengthen cross-regional collaboration and support more effective crisis response.
- **Encourage/promote demand-driven coordination mechanism:** Promote demand-driven coordination mechanisms. The Bangladesh response showed that in rapidly evolving contexts, flexible and demand-driven coordination, supported by frequent interactions and swift decision-making, is more effective than formal mechanisms, which can be slower and less practical in dynamic situations.